important, reason—the now-repealed farm laws, which had practically turned the whole Punjab countryside against the BJP. The 15-month-long farmers' agitation led by Jat Sikh-dominated farm unions on Delhi's borders ensured the contentious laws would be an emotionally charged poll plank that puts the BJP on the backfoot. That's the scenario they are seeking to alter now with a complex balancing act.

The strategy is multi-pronged. One is to try cut their losses within the powerful Jat Sikh community and create some zones of resonance among moderates there—while, in a seeming irony, simultaneously trying to solidify and harness the Hindu vote. This is necessary because, while only 19 per cent of the electorate, as rural landowners, the Jat Sikh arc of influence is wide. The repeal of the farm laws, the BJP hopes, will assuage this irate segment. Alongside, the fact that the SAD is seen as having deviated from the panthic agenda creates a gap the BJP is seeking to fill with some favourable symbolism. The Kartarpur Corridor, foreign grants for gurudwaras, keeping langars out of the purview of GST, evacuating Sikh families and retrieving copies of the Guru Granth Sahib during the Taliban takeover of Afghanistan...all that will help. The BJP is also beefing up its ranks with Sikh leaders—it now has 10 Sikh district presidents and about a fourth of its cadre is from the community. The induction of the kinsfolk of former Akali stalwarts Gurcharan Singh Tohra and Surjit Singh Barnala will do no harm to that outreach.

Two, their new allies give them access to new territories. Former CM Amarinder Singh's Punjab Lok Congress (PLC) has a footprint across the so-called 'royal Punjab' belt: Patiala, Faridkot, Bathinda, Muktsar. And Sukhdev Dhindsa's SAD (Sanyukt) is strong in Sangrur, Barnala, Malerkotla and Mansa. The BJP being on the same side as Amarinder may prima facie seem a contradiction but it resolves an old ambiguity in the saffron camp—a tacit reluctance to go all out against the former royal. The party has in the past mostly stopped short of venturing electorally into Patiala district, Amarinder's stronghold, choosing to do so only in Rajpura seat. Indeed, RSS-affiliated outfits have in previous elections even transferred a substantial number of its votes to the Congress in that whole Malwa belt—against the BJP's ally, the Akalis—courtesy Amarinder's image as a moderate Sikh and nationalist. This time it will be frank and open synergy, even if the fledgling PLC is not expected to make a big impact (there's even speculation that Amarinder may ask many of his leaders to contest on a BJP ticket).

The third axis the BJP hopes to prise open, to try and neutralise the Charanjit Singh Channi-led Congress government's strengths, relates to Punjab's caste and community map. The state's 30 million population is made up of several voting blocs. Panthic voters—Sikhs who tend to vote on religious rather than secular issues—determine the outcome in 48 of the 117 assembly seats. Dalits, straddling the Hindu-Sikh divide, constitute 32 per cent of the electorate—a solid 24.8 per cent of Punjab's voters are Dalit Sikhs. And OBCs, divided into 60 subcastes, are another 32 per cent.

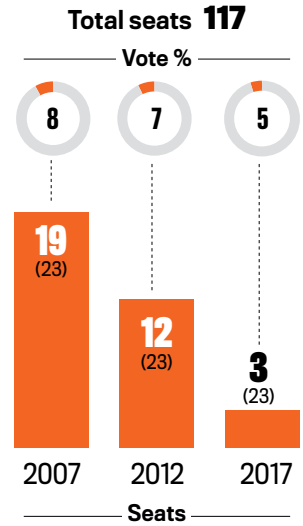
Caste Hindus, who dominate 45 urban seats, are the BJP's natural catchment area, so its concerns are sharp-focused on the Dalit votebank—Ravidasis, Ramdasi Sikhs and Adi-Dharmis, plus Mazhabi Sikhs and their old Hindu parent branch, Valmikis. It is here that Channi, Punjab's first Dalit CM, is posing a serious challenge, especially in the Doaba region. A Ramdasi Sikh himself, he has been mobilising these segments and trying to build equations across Dalit subcastes. He may contest from Adampur in Doaba, a region with a 45 per cent Dalit population, banking on the support of the Dera Sach Khand Ballan, a Ravidasi organisation. The BJP, in turn keen to split that potential axis by wooing Mazhabi Sikhs and Valmikis, is promising the community a much higher representation.

The BJP, which has two seats in the outgoing assembly, aims to contest from 70 constituencies, leaving the remaining 47 for its allies. It will be a Herculean task, no doubt: their voteshare, 8 per cent in 2007, had actually dipped to 5 per cent in the 2017 assembly poll, where they scored only three seats—and that was at the height of Modi's popularity. To their credit, despite the hostility faced during the farmers' agitation, the BJP claims to have built up a presence in all 24,689 polling booths in the state. Naturally, there's the usual competition between newfound friends. "Good leaders from other parties are welcome to join the BJP. But we must not open our doors to opportunists," says a top BJP leader from Punjab. "We have strong candidates in Hindu-dominated seats. The BJP leadership should take them into confidence before giving tickets to entrants from other parties."

That's why it sees the benefits brought by the alliances—an incremental boost to voteshare, plus the influx of Amarinder loyalists like Rana Sodhi, MLA from Guru Harsahai; ex-Sangrur MLA Arvind Khanna and Fatehjang Singh Bajwa, MLA from Qadian—as only part of a larger gameplan. The real trick will lie in softening the hostility among Jat Sikhs and woo the Dalits while keeping its caste-Hindu vote a unified phalanx. That's where the language of security and nationalism comes in. Will Ferozepur be Punjab's Pulwama? We'll know by March 10. ■

A LOW BASE

BJP fortunes in the past three assembly polls it contested as SAD's junior partner



() Seats contested